A ‘Den Mother’ Recollects Bharat Jodo

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I think each of us craves to do something unique that not only gives purpose to our lives but also redefines the world. This is especially true for me, who has grown up hearing stories of how my late great-grandfather, Dhanaji Nana Chaudhari, played a pivotal role in organizing the Congress party’s first rural convention at Faizpur in 1937. Three generations of my family have been in the Congress and kept adding to this treasure trove of stories that I have cherished. So when the Bharat Jodo Yatra was announced, I felt that a rare opportunity to do something meaningful had presented itself to me.

In Maharashtra, civil society organizations organically added the prefix ‘Nafrat Chhodo (Shed Hatred)’, both to tip a hat to the 1942 Bharat Chhodo (Quit India) movement and to make the BJY their own. It was rightly felt that unifying ‘Bharat’ was a utopian dream. Although this may seem like an abstract and lofty idea, it automatically signalled to lakhs of progressive people in Maharashtra that the Yatra was against those forces that were undemocratic, illiberal and against secularism. And although no one said it was against the politics of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), ironically protests were organized against Nafrat Chhodo, thus indirectly conceding the original point.

In parallel, within the Congress party in Maharashtra, the Congress Legislative Party leader Balasaheb Thorat and Mohan Joshi (the convenor and co-convenor for the Maharashtra BJY) first distributed tasks to various committees headed by multiple leaders. This included accommodation, food and toilets for state and district yatris, social media and media publicity, security and passes, sites and structures for the daily corner meetings and